Winter Semester

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Introduction

Digital literacy is one of the most essential skills for students in today's technology driven world. It basically involves the ability to use digital tools effectively, communicate responsibly online, and understand how to stay safe while using the internet. As students, we depend heavily on digital platforms for learning, collaboration and communication, which is why developing digital awareness has become so important, especially at the college level.

This project was designed to help students like me explore different aspects of digital literacy through a series of practical tasks. These tasks included creating a digital awareness infographic, building a student digital portfolio, exploring coding and collaboration platforms, practicing professional email communication, and studying cybercrime awareness. Each task focused on building responsible digital habits and improving our familiarity with useful online tools. Through this project I feel I have gained a much better understanding of how to navigate the digital world safely and professionally.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Infographic

For Task 1, I created a digital literacy awareness infographic using Canva. The main purpose of this infographic was to present key information about digital literacy in a visually clear and engaging format that would be easy for my batchmates to understand and actually find useful. I chose Canva because it is beginner friendly and offers a lot of ready made templates that made the designing process much more manageable for me.

The infographic covered three key topics which were digital literacy, safe internet practices, and email etiquette. The first section explained digital literacy as the ability to use digital tools and online platforms responsibly and effectively. The second section highlighted safe internet practices, which included using strong passwords, avoiding suspicious links and protecting personal information online. The third section discussed email etiquette, focusing on the importance of clear subject lines, professional language, and proper greetings while communicating through email.

Designing this infographic was a really good learning experience for me. One challenge I personally faced was keeping the content concise while also making the layout look clean and readable at the same time. Its honestly more difficult then it sounds to balance design and information together, but I am happy with how it turned out.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

In Task 2, I built a basic digital portfolio by creating and setting up accounts on three platforms which were GitHub, LinkedIn and HackerRank. These platforms are widely used in both professional and academic settings, and I feel they are essential for any student who wants to establish a strong digital presence early on in there career.

On GitHub, I created a profile README that introduces me as a first year Integrated M.Tech student at VIT Bhopal University. To be honest, I had never used GitHub before this project, but after setting it up I genuinely feel it is one of the most useful platforms for a tech student. It lets you maintain a visible record of all your work and projects, which I think is really valuable especially when applying for internships later.

I also updated my LinkedIn profile by adding my education details including my university, degree and expected graduation year. LinkedIn is a very important professional networking platform and I plan to keep updating it regularly as I grow in my academic and professional journey.

Additionally I created a HackerRank account which I plan to use consistently for coding practice over the next five years. Overall this task gave me a much clearer idea of what a professional digital presence actually looks like.

Task 3 – Coding & Collaboration Platforms

Task 3 was probably my favourite task in this entire project because it was the most hands on and practical one out of all five.

For the coding component, I used HackerRank and completed a beginner level challenge called "Solve Me First." The challenge required me to write a simple program that reads two integers and outputs there sum. It sounds simple but it was actually a great introduction to how competitive coding platforms work, how you submit your solutions, and how automated test cases are used to evaluate them. For someone like me who is just starting out with programming, this was a really useful first step.

For the collaboration component, I created a Google Form called "Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz" which had five questions related to digital literacy and online safety. What I found really interesting was that all the responses were automatically collected in a linked Google Sheet, which showed me how powerful Google Workspace tools actually are for collecting and managing data. I had used Google Forms before but never really paid attention to how the backend worked. Going forward I can definitely see myself using both HackerRank and Google Workspace regularly throughout my five year programme for both academic and personal projects.

Task 4 – Professional Email Communication

Task 4 was focused on learning proper email etiquette and professional online communication. For this task I drafted two professional emails, one requesting an assignment deadline extension from a professor and another expressing interest in a summer internship opportunity. Both emails were written keeping in mind the proper structure which includes a clear subject line, a respectful greeting, a well organised body and a proper sign off.

Working on this task made me realise that email etiquette is something a lot of students, including myself, tend to overlook. A situation where poor digital communication can cause a real problem is when a student sends an email to a professor without a subject line, uses very informal language, and doesn't clearly explain what they need. This honestly gives a very bad impression and the email might not even get a response. What should have been done differently is simply following a proper email format and maintaining a polite and clear tone throughout, which is not very difficult but makes a huge difference in how you come across professionally.

Social Media Do's and Don'ts

Do's	**Don'ts**
Keep your profiles professional and regularly updated	Don't post anything you wouldn't want your professor or future employer to see
Always use strong and unique passwords for each account	Don't share personal details like your phone number or address publicly
Think carefully before sharing anything — once its online its very hard to take back	Don't engage with or spread unverified news and rumors online
Report any cyberbullying or online harassment immediately	Don't scroll through social media during lectures or exams
Check and update your privacy settings on all platforms regularly	Don't accept follow or friend requests from people you don't personally know

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness

For Task 5 I researched UPI fraud which is currently one of the most widespread forms of cybercrime in India. UPI fraud usually happens when scammers trick people into either sharing sensitive financial details or unknowingly approving fraudulent payment

requests, mostly through fake calls or messages pretending to be from a bank or payment app.

What surprised me the most during this research was honestly how convincing these scammers actually are. I always thought that most people would be able to identify a scam call pretty easily, but after reading about how these frauds actually work, I realised that even educated and careful individuals can fall for them. That was genuinely eye opening for me.

One habit I am personally going to change after this is that I will always verify a payment request properly before approving it, no matter how urgent it seems. I will also never share any financial information over a call or message and will be a lot more careful while using UPI apps going forward.

Conclusion

This project was genuinely a very useful and eye opening experience for me. Through the different tasks I got to learn how to create digital content, set up a professional digital portfolio, explore coding and collaboration platforms, practice proper email communication, and understand the cybercrime risks that are very much relevant in today's world.

What I took away the most from this project is that digital literacy is not just about knowing how to use technology, its about using it responsibly and safely. I plan to continue building on everything I learned here, especially on GitHub and HackerRank, and will keep improving my digital skills throughout my five year Integrated M.Tech programme. Overall this was one of the more practical and meaningful assignments I have done so far.

References

- Canva – https://www.canva.com
- GitHub – https://github.com
- LinkedIn – https://www.linkedin.com
- HackerRank – https://www.hackerrank.com
- Google Forms – https://forms.google.com
- National Cyber Crime Portal – https://cybercrime.gov.in